

THE AUSTRALIAN GOVERNMENT HAS BEEFED UP POLICING AROUND ALL ITS EDUCATIONAL INSTITUTIONS.

Canberra announced that a senior security official would head a new taskforce to look into such attacks. Foreign Minister Stephen Smith said National Security Adviser Duncan Lewis would coordinate the response of authorities involved in tackling the issue. Smith said: "Australia again sends a message to the Indian people that Australia is serious about ensuring the safety of Indian students, as we are serious about ensuring the safety of all visitors to our country."

Most Indian students in Victoria believe that racism is to blame, but Australia is an egalitarian country that prides itself on its migrant stock and its multi-cultural heritage. Yes, it is true that "people of Indian origin" were the victims in more reported cases of robberies and assaults. But it must be pointed out that the number of Indian students has more than doubled in the past three years. Victoria Police Chief Commissioner Simon Overland said that statistics of crimes in these years did not show that Indians were being targeted. But he said that he would confront the issue in every possible way, even taking the unprecedented decision to mingle among and speak to the hundreds of Indian students who blocked a major city intersection at the start of the week.

What was of concern was that the attacks had been growing steadily over the past few months. On February 19 this year, *The Age*, the Melbourne broadsheet newspaper, reported that robberies in the city's western suburbs had increased by almost 30 per cent. Disproportionately, almost a third of the victims, according to the police, "were of Indian appearance". Before the mainstream media first began reporting the attacks, Gautam Gupta of the Federation of Indian Students of Australia said it was difficult to bring serious attention to the trend. Gupta also said that the attacks had been geographically concentrated in the west-



THE CAMPUS OF THE UNIVERSITY OF NEW SOUTH WALES IN SYDNEY

ern suburbs. It was an interesting observation. Land and house prices as well as rents are cheaper in the western suburbs and it is not surprising that some Indian students choose to find accommodation there.

At the time, police spokesman Commander Trevor Carter said there was no specific group involved in the attacks on Indian students. He admitted, however, that officers had been monitoring the problem for almost 18 months. "There was a range of victims, but people of Indian backgrounds were over-represented in the crime statistics," he said. Immediately, the police launched a special operation designed to increase their presence at train stations in the area so as to dissuade potential gang activity. Simultaneously, Indian students were advised not to flaunt electronic equipment such as iPods and cellphones.

Shortly after, Footscray MP Marsha Thomson said she had been in consultation with students who had been attacked and had concluded that some of them were afraid to report crimes, on the mistaken assumption that any interaction with police might harm their migration chances. Dinesh

Malhotra, founding editor of the *Bharat Times* newspaper, confirmed that some of the early assaults might have gone unreported to authorities. He explained that many victims were under the mistaken impression that they could be stripped of their status as overseas students. "Yes, some of the students are scared," he said. "They even have the mistaken idea that they could be deported simply for reporting these matters to the police."

A string of pro-active measures are now being put into place. The Police in the Footscray area joined forces with Victoria University to produce a DVD with a safety advice aimed at new students. Officers have also gone great lengths to locate victims of crime in the western suburbs and subsequently filed 50 charges over attacks. Even as New Zealand makes the first overtures to Indian students in the hope that it would be considered a viable alternative, the real issue confronting Australia now is to put an end to the attacks. Australia must now prove to India that it is also The Safe Country.

The author was born and educated in India and now works as a journalist in a Melbourne daily